

Heal the WORLD

India's medical tourism ecosystem has gone through many phases. From just being affordable, it now offers more value. But more needs to be done

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THE 1991 economic reforms created multiple opportunities for Indian companies. If the first few years were about figuring out the new business milieu, big-ticket events such as Y2K opened the global IT industry to us. The larger learning was that India could deliver high quality at an affordable cost.

After IT, it was the turn of healthcare. As private hospital networks continue to proliferate on the back of robust business models and more access to funding, confidence levels have increased. Treatment of patients from other countries—medical tourism as it is called—is now a \$12-billion industry, and growing. Again, affordability is the differentiator, without compromising on quality. Steadily, things have improved, and with some more push, India can get a disproportionate share of the global market.

THE TIPPING POINTS

Like any other industry, medical tourism has gone through periods of change. Ritu Garg, Chief Growth & Innovation Officer, Fortis Healthcare, points to three distinct phases. The early 2000s were about

cost-advantage, driven primarily by affordability. “International patients travelled to India because they could access world-class treatment at a fraction of the cost in developed markets. This cost advantage positioned India as a viable alternative for complex procedures such as cardiac surgery, orthopaedics, oncology and transplants,” she says.

The 2010s saw Indian hospitals focusing on infrastructure and capability building. They invested in advanced technology, internationally trained clinicians, quality accreditations (JCI/NABH) and patient-centric services. From the late 2010s to the present, specialised outcome-driven care has become important. Garg says patients, who once came to India for affordability, now seek specialised expertise, shorter waiting times, access to advanced therapies and demonstrated

